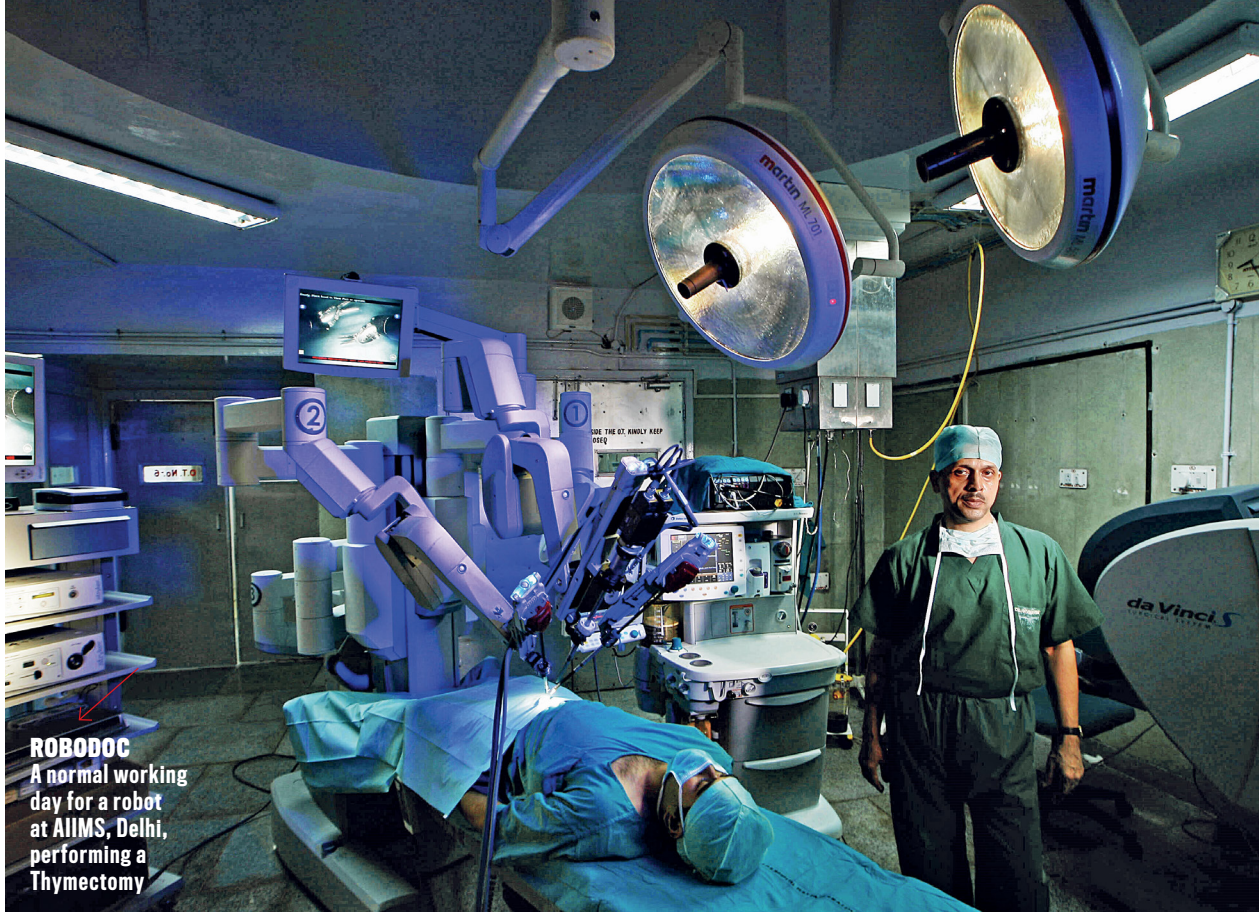


ROBODOC
A normal working day for a robot at AIIMS, Delhi, performing a Thymectomy

BANDEEP SINGH

FREEDOM@75 HEALTH

FEELING MUCH BETTER

But India's health is still a work in progress. The spectacular progress on many fronts—from the brick and mortar, to the doctors and nurses who animate it, to disease eradication—also alerts us to the stark gaps

By ***Sonali Acharjee***

In 1947, India's entire healthcare infrastructure consisted of some 700 primary care centres and 7,000-odd hospitals/ dispensaries. Today, we count over 30,000 PHCs, 69,000 hospitals and nearly 2 million hospital beds—with the transformative touch of technology visible across the spectrum, including in the eSanjeevani telemedicine outreach that caters to nearly 35,000 patients daily in remote areas (3 million consultations till date, across 31 states). India also has the world's largest health insurance scheme—since it began in 2018, Ayushman Bharat has provided Rs 7,000 crore and free treatment 10 million times to patients from the 100 million poor families eligible for a Rs 1 lakh cover. Some 40,000-odd new wellness centres too are operational, of the scheme's sanctioned 62,000. And yet, the gaps are massive and the skew decidedly favours urban areas (*see graphics*). Even there, Covid-19 gave us a stark picture of limitations and awakened everyone to